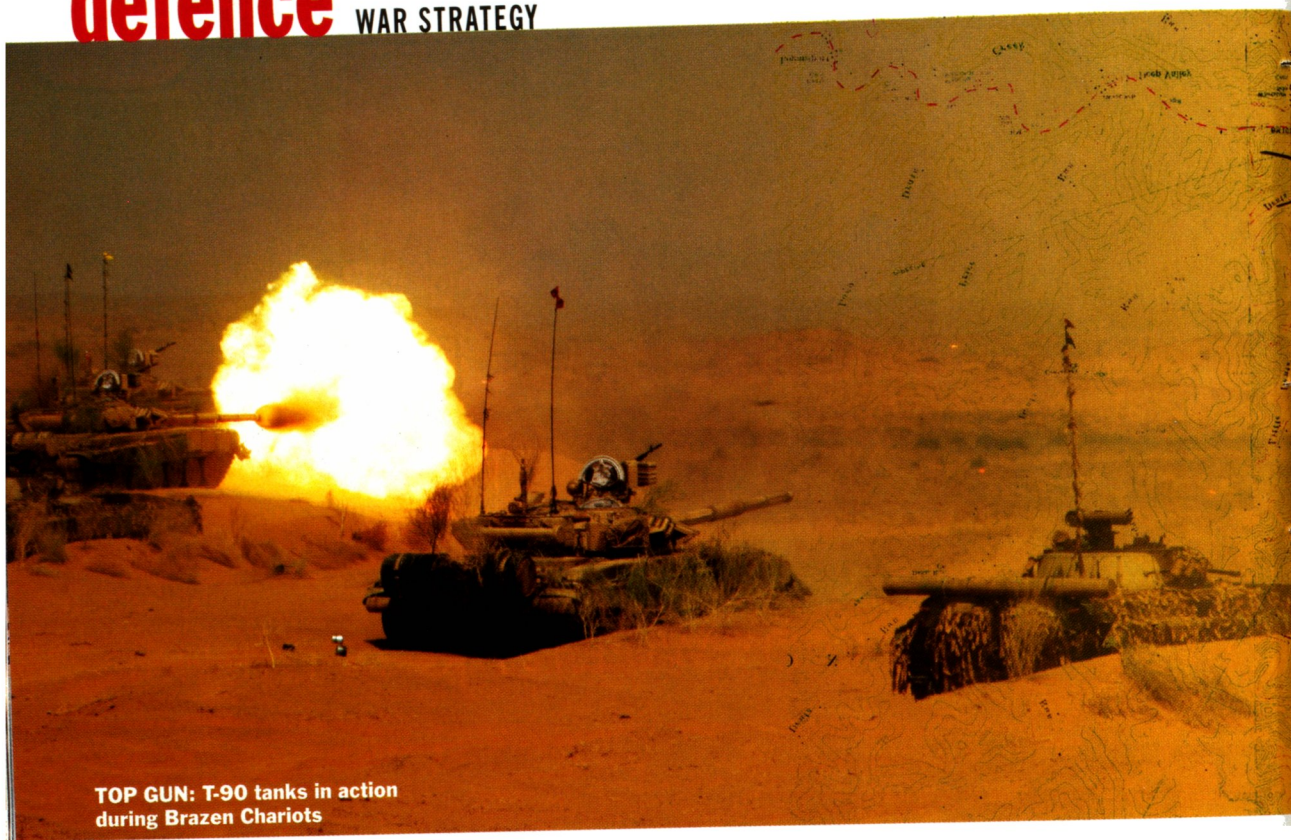




TOP GUN: T-90 tanks in action during Brazen Chariots

FAST AND FURIOUS

The army refines its Cold Start warfighting doctrine which employs maximum force in minimum time in swift operations under a nuclear overhang, but is still some years away from perfecting it

■ **By Sandeep Unnithan**

It was a costly lesson in futility that the nation can do well not to forget. Soon after the attack on the Parliament on December 13, 2001, an outraged government ordered the largest mobilisation of the armed forces since the 1971 war. The army amassed on the border waiting for the order to go across. The order never came because it had taken the army three weeks to mobilise—enough time for the United States and the rest of the world to pressure the Indian government to desist and for Pakistan to mirror Indian deployments and wave the spectre of a nuclear conflict.

Two years after Operation

Parakram ended in an ignominious 10-month deployment, followed by a withdrawal, the army pulled out Cold Start, a radical new strategy to deal with such contingencies. The challenge: Could the Indian Army launch an offensive within 72 hours of being told to do so? It has spent the past four years finetuning it. Last week at Pokhran they unveiled just how well they had tuned the war machine for a jump-start.

The Thar desert reverberated with the roar of an exercise appropriately termed Brazen Chariots. Heavily armoured Mi-35 Hind helicopter gunships darted back and forth, T-90 tanks advanced, kicking up plumes of sand and Bofors howitzers moved into position.

War had broken out between Red

Land and Blue Land. In the darkened underground command post of a 'Blue Land' division, Major General P.G. Karnat studied his key objectives: the capture of the Danwar base 40 km deep inside Red Land. Held by a brigade of enemy troops it housed a major communications hub.

Within hours of the conflict breaking out, the armoured division spearheaded by T-90 tanks was wheeling across the desert towards Danwar. Sukhoi-30 MKIs, MiG-27s and MiG-21 Bisons streaked overhead, bombing and strafing enemy fortifications with precision guided munitions and air-to-ground rockets. Bofors howitzers spewed devastating fire—100 guns fired on a single target in a 1 km box—